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THE PARENT GUIDE SERIES



VOLUME 7 · FREE STARTER GUIDE

IHSS Protective Supervision

A Parent's Quick Guide

Clear guidance for the benefits journey

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Written from my own experience. IHSS is a California program — this guide covers California's rules.

A note from Beth

It took me six years to learn I could ask about Protective Supervision. My daughter was already getting IHSS, but her hours were low. When I told her psychiatrist how many hours she was getting, she couldn't believe it. She explained what I could ask for and wrote a letter to help.

I called IHSS midyear and asked for a reassessment. My daughter's behaviors had changed, and her hours didn't cover the supervision she needed. The caseworker scheduled a home visit. I put together a binder with copies of my daily safety journal, the psychiatrist's letter, and a short summary of my daughter's IEP.

One of my daughter's Regional Center providers came to the visit and shared what she'd seen during her own sessions. About a week later, the decision came in the mail. My daughter was approved for Protective Supervision, and her total IHSS hours went from under 100 a month to 283.

I wish I'd known sooner what to ask for and who could help. I'm sharing what I learned so you have a place to start. You can do this, one step at a time.

Know what to ask for

Protective Supervision is a California In-Home Supportive Services (IHSS) service. Autism, Alzheimer's or another dementia, an intellectual disability, or a mental health condition may affect safety. Eligibility depends on how the condition affects the person in daily life — not on the diagnosis alone.

What the county looks at

- **Memory.** Does your child forget a safety instruction, or forget to finish a task in a way that creates a risk?
- **Orientation.** Does your child get confused about where they are, who is with them, or how to get back to a familiar place?
- **Judgment.** Does your child make an unsafe choice, such as stepping off a curb without understanding the danger?
- **Nonself-directing.** Because of an impairment, the person cannot reliably recognize or assess danger and is likely to do something that puts them at risk of accidental injury.

Underneath all four is the same test: the person needs **supervision around the clock** to remain safely at home. For a minor, the county also looks at whether the child needs more supervision than a same-age child without the impairment.

Where to start: If you're applying for IHSS, bring up Protective Supervision at the initial assessment. If your child already receives IHSS and their needs have changed, call your county IHSS worker and ask for a reassessment — you don't have to wait for the annual visit.

Document what happens — and bring in your team

Keep a daily safety journal

Write down the date, what happened, where it happened, and what you did to keep your child safe. A close call counts as something worth writing down. If it happened once, say it happened once. For example, note if your child stepped into the street before checking for traffic, or unlocked the door and went outside before anyone noticed.

Use the state's criteria to describe your child in your own words: what happened, what danger your child missed, and how you stepped in.

Ask the clinician to put it in writing

My daughter's psychiatrist wrote a letter, and it carried real weight. Ask the IHSS worker about **SOC 821**, the state's Protective Supervision assessment form for a physician or other appropriate medical professional. Ask your child's clinician to describe the needs they can speak to.

Talk with the people who see your child day to day

I spoke with my daughter's teacher and aides. I also asked her Regional Center provider directly if she could join the home visit. We talked beforehand about the concerns I planned to raise, and she shared examples from her own sessions. If a provider can't attend in person, ask if they could join by phone if the worker can arrange it, or send a short note.

Make the most of the home visit

Put your strongest examples first

My routine annual visits usually lasted ten minutes or less, so I wanted the caseworker to have something to review afterward. I made a binder with copies of my safety journal, the psychiatrist's letter, and a short summary of my daughter's Individualized Education Program (IEP). I offered to send the full IEP if she needed it.

Bring up your biggest safety concern early. Share one or two examples of what happened and how you stepped in. My daughter's IEP described both her strengths and the behaviors staff had seen over the years that affected what she could do independently. If someone joins the visit, give them a chance to describe what they've seen firsthand.

Keep the conversation open

Ask whether the caseworker needs anything else, such as the full IEP or a Regional Center Individual Program Plan (IPP). Ask how to send it, and when to check back. Keep a note of what you sent and when.

Watch for the written decision. IHSS sends a Notice of Action after a reassessment. Read it to see what the county decided and how many hours it authorized. My decision came about a week after the home visit.

Your Protective Supervision checklist

- ☐ Start the daily safety journal: date, what happened, where, and what you did
- ☐ Write down your biggest safety concern in one or two examples
- ☐ Ask the IHSS worker about the SOC 821 form for your child's clinician
- ☐ Ask a teacher, aide, or Regional Center provider to join the visit — or send a short note
- ☐ Build the visit binder: journal copies, the clinician's letter, a short IEP summary
- ☐ At the visit, lead with your strongest example
- ☐ Ask what else the caseworker needs, how to send it, and when to check back
- ☐ When the Notice of Action arrives, read what was decided and how many hours were authorized

What the full guide adds

The complete **IHSS Protective Supervision: The Step-by-Step Parent Guide** (Volume 7, $9) walks the whole request in order, with tools you can print and use: the daily safety log, with a filled-in example · the home-visit binder checklist and cover page · the one-page IEP summary worksheet, with a filled-in example · the one-sentence phone script for asking for a reassessment · copy-and-paste messages — asking a provider to join the visit, and following up with the caseworker · and how to read the Notice of Action, including the state-hearing deadlines if the answer is no.

Get it at **anchorandableco.com** or on **Gumroad** — search Anchor & Able.

Questions along the way? I'm a resource too: **anchorandableco@gmail.com** · **@anchorandableco**. Guidance from lived experience — I'm not an attorney, and this isn't legal advice. IHSS is a California program; the sources behind this guide are California's: the IHSS regulations (MPP §§ 30-757.17 and 30-761.219), the California Department of Social Services SOC 821 form, and LA County DPSS Protective Supervision policy.